

SIRĀT

Deserts Are Not Empty



What are we to make of *Sirāt* (Óliver Laxe, 2025), other than as one of the bleakest depictions in recent cinematic history of the brutal randomness of the human condition? Or as further evidence in support of Bruno Latour's contention that "we have never been modern"?

Shot mostly in the crushing heat of the Moroccan desert in the summer of 2024, the Spanish-French co-production was awarded the Jury Prize at the Cannes Film Festival 2025, in spite (or perhaps because) of its emotionally devastating and graphic content. This paper attempts to make sense of the film by framing it in relation to two historical antecedents: the long history of cinematic representations of the desert in Hollywood and other world cinemas; and the countercultural imaginary of Morocco as a site of societal and sexual freedom, from the writings of Paul Bowles and Jean Genet, or Brian Jones's musical encounter with the Jajouka brotherhood, to the colonisation of the Moroccan desert (amongst others) by the ecstatic nomads of rave culture.

While as the contributors to a recent collection of essays and creative writing pointedly titled *Deserts Are Not Empty* (Samia Henni, ed., 2022) argue, western cinema has typically depicted deserts within a colonial worldview, as empty spaces awaiting territorialization by imperial powers, the ravers of *Sirāt* soon discover that the apparently empty territory they occupy is traversed by local geopolitical struggles and the larger transnational forces that shape them. Even the supposedly pristine wilderness of the desert is striated by the minefield that ultimately obliterates most of the cast still left standing. Rave culture itself, while ostensibly a hedonistic alternative practice to western bourgeois society, is revealed as a fantasy of escape from the geopolitical landscapes that they seek to claim and inhabit like colonial settlers, and as just another form of alienation from the brutal realities of the world.

While *Sirāt*'s vision of the world may seem unrelentingly bleak, the paper argues, the film can also be read as a scathing indictment of human alienation both from the planet itself and of the societies that continue to contest its sublime landscapes.

Bibliography

Henni, Samia, ed. *Deserts Are Not Empty*. New York: Columbia Books on Architecture and the City, 2022.

Paper proposal for Rethinking
Transnational Cinema(s)
Global Cinema Symposium,
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Filmography

Lawrence of Arabia (David Lean, 1962)

Fata Morgana (Werner Herzog, 1970)

The Sheltering Sky (Bernardo Bertolucci, 1990) *Mad Max: Fury Road* (George Miller, 2015) *Sirāt* (Óliver Laxe, 2025)

Bio

Martin Roberts is a faculty member in the School of Film, Television, and Media Arts at Emerson College. His research focuses on transnational media cultures. His publications include essays on ethnographic documentary, the globalisation of IMAX cinema, the concept of film culture, the Dogma '95 movement, postfeminist television, and global subcultures. His most recent book is on Japanese popular music for the 33 1/3 album series, titled *Cornelius's 'Fantasma'*. His current research focuses on the concept of the 'cinematic' and its legacy in contemporary digital culture.
